Although al-Qaeda remained the most high-profile international jihadist group in the years that followed, Islamist attacks continued to take place with alarming regularity around the world: Bali, Beslan, Madrid, London, Boston, Paris, Brussels, Dhaka, etc. India was not immune: major terrorist attacks on urban centres such as Delhi, Mumbai, and Bengaluru picked up after the 1990s, peaking after 2000 until the 26/11 attacks in 2008 in Mumbai. Another wave of attacks against urban civilian targets took place between about 2010 and 2013 before terrorists and their sponsors opted to focus their efforts on military and law enforcement targets in India. But throughout this period, the regular terrorist attacks in India were linked to a wide-ranging international terrorist infrastructure that encompassed training, recruitment, and financing networks. Pakistan and Afghanistan were an epicentre of such activity. [12]

Even before bin Laden's death, but especially in the years that followed, Islamism began to assume new forms. In 2010, a series of demonstrations across West Asia and North Africa against established dictatorships—known as the 'Arab Spring'—resulted in new governments in Tunisia and Egypt, and the outbreak of civil wars in Syria, Libya, and Yemen. While initially viewed in the West as a flourishing of democratic forces, the Arab Spring instead saw Islamists attempt to establish themselves in many Arab countries. In particular, the political turmoil in Egypt, where the Muslim Brotherhood briefly came to power, was viewed with alarm in many Middle Eastern capitals. Additionally, the Syrian Civil War and a vacuum of power in northern and western Iraq created the conditions for the rise of a new group, the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS, also knowns as IS, ISIL, or Daesh). ISIS distinguished itself from other jihadist groups, including al-Qaeda, by its focus on creating a state with a defined territory. [13] In June 2014, ISIS leader Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi declared a new 'caliphate', claiming leadership of the global Islamist jihadist movement. Around the world, older Islamist movements such as Boko Haram in Nigeria and Abu Sayyaf in the Philippines pledged allegiance to the new 'caliphate' of ISIS.

For a time, ISIS was successful in establishing jurisdiction in Syria and Iraq and building its global presence online and through affiliations. A large